could barely negotiate the slush-like conditions on either side of Se-la and eventually Dalvi had to walk from Senge to Jang before being picked up and driven to Tawang.

Just before Dalvi arrived in Assam, Kaul had spelt out his plans for Operation Onkar, which was to commence in April 1962. This operation was under the larger umbrella of the Forward Policy, conceived by Nehru's close advisers led by Mullik, to avoid a second 'Aksai Chin'. As such, it is likely that the main thrust of the new policy was primarily meant for Ladakh, even though the Prime Minister's directive of 2 November 1960 had said 'that Indian forces should remain in effective occupation of the whole frontier from NEFA to Ladakh and they should cover all gaps by effective patrolling. No longer should the Chinese be allowed to encroach surreptitiously into our territories not occupied by Indian troops or police'. However, by the time the implications of the new policy were understood, the winter of 1961-1962 had set in. Despite the fact that the Western Sector by itself would require massive logistical support to implement the policy, Kaul expanded its scope to include the Central and Eastern Sectors into the gambit of the new policy. That the eastern sector was an afterthought is supported by the fact that until February 1962, Eastern Command was not aware of Operation Onkar. Secondly, April as the date of commencement was related purely to Ladakh for, until then, it was not possible to airlift the required infantry battalions required for the task.

In the Eastern Sector, there was yet another important change in the command structure—Major General Amrik Singh was posted out just as Operation Onkar was commencing. The new GOC of 4 Infantry Division, Major General Niranjan Prasad, was only due to take over in May 1962. The commanding officer of 9 Punjab was also posted out and replaced by Lieutenant Colonel R. N. Mishra. Although Dalvi as the brigade commander had operational control of the sector on the ground, the Assam Rifles continued to function as a virtual private army of the Ministry of External Affairs. Their administration was under the inspector general based in Shillong and there was no inter-communication facilities between the Assam Rifles posts and the closest army sub-posts. To complicate matters even more, 7 Infantry Brigade was functioning without any useful intelligence.

Meanwhile, the Intelligence Bureau had tabled a detailed report on 17 May 1962, which stated that the Chinese had considerably reinforced their